

Journeyways

A board game about becoming.

Journeyways

Game Rules
Edition 1.0, 2026

Game design and text: Adri M.

JOURNEYWAYS is a master's research project at the UBC Institute for Gender, Race, Sexuality and Social Justice, Vancouver, Canada.

All the game's documents can be downloaded at journeyways.ca/components.

Set in Nunito and Italianno, both under the SIL Open Font License.

GAME DOCUMENTS
journeyways.ca/components

THE LICENCE
CC BY-NC 4.0

© 2025-2026 Adri M. This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0 International licence (CC BY-NC 4.0). You may copy, share and adapt it for non-commercial purposes, as long as you give credit. To view a copy of the licence, visit creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc/4.0.

JOURNEYWAYS

Game Rules

Step into a world where identity is not chosen but uncovered.
In JOURNEYWAYS, you don't play to win; you play to unfold.
Explore selfhood not with labels, but with motion, memory, and meaning.
Whether solo or in chorus, each session reveals a story made only by your presence.
With no fixed roles and no final answers, JOURNEYWAYS invites you to co-create the story of who you are and who you are becoming.

This manual will help you learn how to begin your journey of becoming.





A few of the places your journey may take you.

Table of contents

Game setup **2**

What you'll need *2*

Initial setup *2*

Basic gameplay **3**

Turn structure *3*

1. Explore *3*

2. Pick *3*

3. Reflect *3*

Ending the game **4**

Writing your journal **5**

Solo and group play **7**

Solo play *7*

Group play *7*

Advanced concepts **8**

Session endings *8*

Returning to previous sessions *8*

Creating your own elements *8*

Tips for meaningful play **9**

Creating a safe space *9*

Deepening the experience *9*

Game setup

For 1 to 6 players, plus a facilitator. If more people want to play, use a second game set.

What you'll need

- Board tiles (47), plus a blank tile (1).
- Game cards (112).
- Playing-piece stands (optional; the piece is a booklet tear-out).
- Player booklet (1 per player; download and print it from journeyways.ca/components).
- Some sticky notes.
- Writing utensils.

Initial setup

1. Shuffle all cards together and place them face down in three piles.
2. Pick one card and place it apart face up. This will be the Discard pile.
3. Shuffle all the board tiles and place them face down in three piles.
4. Each player makes their playing piece from the booklet tear-out, or uses any small token they like.
5. Choose together who starts and a rough turn order. Turns don't need to be rigid: anyone can play when they feel like it, or sit a turn out.
6. The starting player picks a tile from any pile and places it in the middle of the table. This is the first tile, where the journey begins.
7. Taking turns, each player picks a tile from any pile and places it adjacent to another previously placed tile. If it's a blank tile, put it back in the pile and pick again.
8. All players place their pieces on the first tile.

Basic gameplay

Turn structure

Each turn consists of three phases: Explore, Pick, and Reflect. Turns follow the rough order you agreed on, but stay loose: play when you feel ready, or sit a turn out.

1. Explore

For Exploration, you have two options: (1) Pick a map tile and place it adjacent to another one. If you pick a blank tile, you have to create it before placing it. (2) Use a sticky note to draw a new map tile (whatever you want) and place it on top of an existing one where no player is located. After you place your tile, you can move one or two spaces in any direction.

2. Pick

Pick a card from any pile, even the Discard pile. Each colour means something different:



Green (Movement): how you move on the map.



Red (Encounter): something happens on your journey.



Black (Countdown): the passing of time.



Blue (Reflection): a quote to reflect on.



Purple (Group): a group event.

3. Reflect

If you picked a **Green** or **Purple** card, you have to perform the action it indicates. If you picked a **Blue** or **Red** card, take into account what it says, and write a new entry in your journal. If you picked a **Black** card, set it apart. The game ends when the fifth **Black** card is picked. Once you are done with a card, discard it or keep it: it does nothing more in the game, but some players keep their cards as a journal log or as milestones.

Ending the game

The game ends when the fifth **Black** card is picked. Each player can add a final entry to their journal, or just leave it as it is. However, if all players agree you can end the session after any number of **Black** cards are picked, or disregard the **Black** cards and use a timer, etc.

It is okay if your story ends abruptly. You can leave it like that, or return to it in another session.

After ending the game, each player can fill in the character sheet at the end of their player booklet. This way they can see how their character developed during the game: what changed, and what stayed the same.

> **Remember:** the game is not about winning or losing. It is about discovering, exploring, and becoming.





Writing your journal

Unlike traditional games, your character in JOURNEYWAYS emerges through play rather than being predetermined.

Use the game cards as inspiration, not rigid definitions; the main objective is to set your imagination free and write the story you want to tell. Journal entries can be as short or as long, as terse or as detailed as you want.

You can get inspiration from the tile where your piece stands and the text in the card, but you can be as creative as you want. You can write a journal entry, doodle it, or do whatever you like.

The next page shows an example journal entry.



It was a warm summer evening when I stumbled upon a cave entrance. There was a soft breeze, and I could hear music coming from the inside. I did not dare go inside, but, right by the entrance I found a pair of shoes. They were brown and looked well-worn, but something in my mind told me to try them on. I removed the tattered sandals I was wearing and put those shoes on. As soon as I did, I felt lighter, as if I was not standing up by myself but some other unexplained force was lifting me. That made me happy. I only wanted the shoes to look a bit better, not brown and all worn down. When that thought crossed my mind, the shoes changed. Now they were sparkly green boots with red trimmings and golden shoelaces. I loved them and decided to keep them.

As for the cave, I decided to walk by. Maybe I can revisit it some other time.

Solo and group play

Solo play

- Remove the **Purple** cards from the game.
- Focus on deep personal reflection.
- Take as much time as you need.
- Use journaling extensively.
- Create your own pacing.
- Return to previous sessions.

Group play

- Share reflections with others.
- Learn from different perspectives.
- Build collective narratives.
- Support each other's growth.
- Create shared memories.



Advanced concepts

Session endings

How a session ends is explained on page 4. Treat it as a suggestion: agree together on whatever ending suits your group.

Returning to previous sessions

JOURNEYWAYS is designed for ongoing play. Return to previous sessions, revisit old insights, and see how your understanding has evolved. Your character and story continue to develop between sessions.

Creating your own elements



Feel free to add your own places (new tiles on sticky notes), character elements, or game mechanics. You can also adapt any card you pick: change what it says, read it your own way, or go by the image alone.
JOURNEYWAYS is a framework for exploration; make it your own.

Tips for meaningful play

Creating a safe space

- Set aside dedicated time.
- Minimise distractions.
- Create a comfortable environment.
- Honour everyone's privacy.
- Practise active listening.

Deepening the experience

- Ask open-ended questions.
- Embrace uncertainty.
- Allow for silence and reflection.
- Be curious, not judgmental.
- Celebrate small discoveries.



Notes

For your thoughts, sketches, and discoveries.

Notes

For your thoughts, sketches, and discoveries.

Journeyways

A board game about becoming.

Website

www.journeyways.ca

© 2025-2026 Adri M. Licensed under CC BY-NC 4.0.